
JI·SO·GI
ANIME STUDIO TYCOON
Game by Rodrigo Esper
Art by Eisuke Gou & Senkawa Teien
RULEBOOK
EDITION 1.5





After years of being on the brink, one of Japan's biggest anime mega studios finally went under. Bad management? Tough working conditions? A cut-throat industry? Opinions vary on the cause, but one thing is clear—the staff are the ones taking the hit.

To soften the blow, a group of senior employees suggested creating smaller, more manageable studios to absorb the lay-offs. This idea quickly gained traction with support from both the government and private sector, all keen to protect this vital cultural industry.

To avoid past mistakes, investors have one condition: fresh management.

That's where you come in! As one of the newly hired managers, you're stepping into the position of your dreams. But you'll soon find out it's no walk in the park, since, for obvious reasons, morale is at rock bottom.

But that's not all! One of the new studios will be chosen to represent a new wave of Japanese anime, with a big joint investment that will make any idea they envision possible!

The hopes and dreams of these talented folks are now in your hands! Can you boost morale, juggle expectations with a (tight) budget, and create hit anime that captivate audiences? Or will you be buried under debts and miss this incredible opportunity? Time to put your studio management skills to the test and find out!





The name JISOGI comes from 自転車操業 (jitenshasōgyō), an expression that refers to barely keeping a business going by using funds from previous projects (the analogy a bicycle falls over if it stops moving).

COMPONENTS



1x Action board



4x Studio boards



20x Trend cards



4x Player Aid Cards



1x Trend board



1x 1st Player token



2x Solo Challenge Cards



4 sets of 6x Studio Action tokens



4x Lock tokens



3x Popularity Bonus tokens



4x Animation Level tokens



16x Merchandise Deal tokens



18x Hype tokens (value 1)



30x Money tokens (value 1)



18x Hype tokens (value 3)



15x Money tokens (value 3)



8x Point trackers



5x Money tokens (value 10)



12x Opportunity cards
20x Networking cards
18x Debt cards



16x Dead-Inside Staff cards
52x Genki Staff cards



20x Setting Script Parts
20x Plot Script Parts
20x Twist Script Parts

The component list of the Edition 1.5 differs slightly from the Founders Edition of the game.

GAME INTRODUCTION

Welcome to JISOGI! Before diving into the rules, let's go over some key concepts to help you navigate this rulebook more easily.

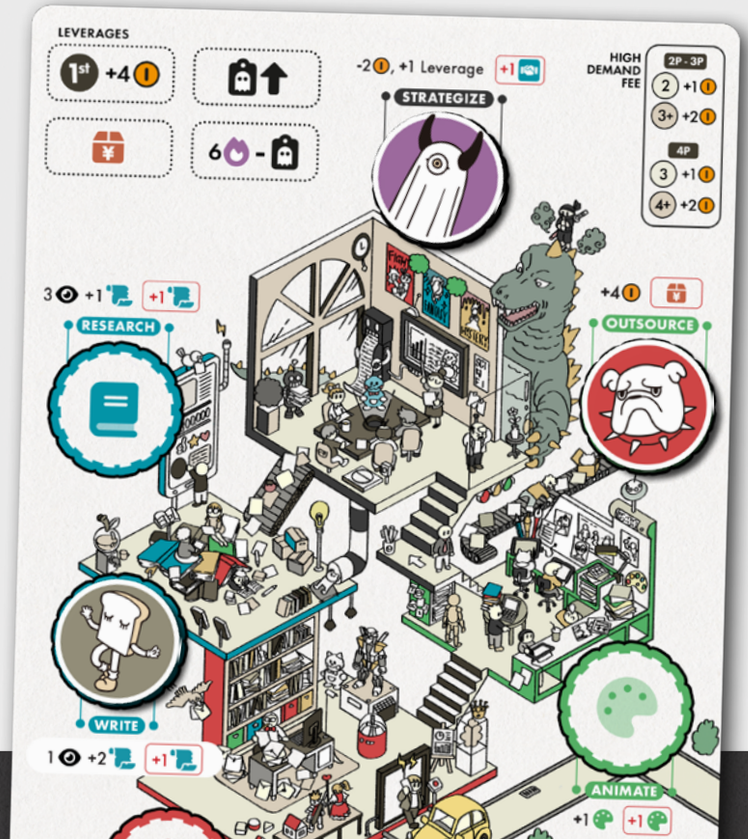
Tycoon-style games aim to simulate the experience of running a business: managing budget, staff, and development strategies. And that is exactly what you will be doing here!

In JISOGI, players run their own anime studio, dealing with a tight budget, traumatized staff, and looming debts. By making smart decisions and following the right trends, you may capitalize on business opportunities, and recruit eager talent to reverse your studio's fortune.

The first zone you will need to get familiar with is the central area, where the Action board and common components pools are located (see Central Area Setup).

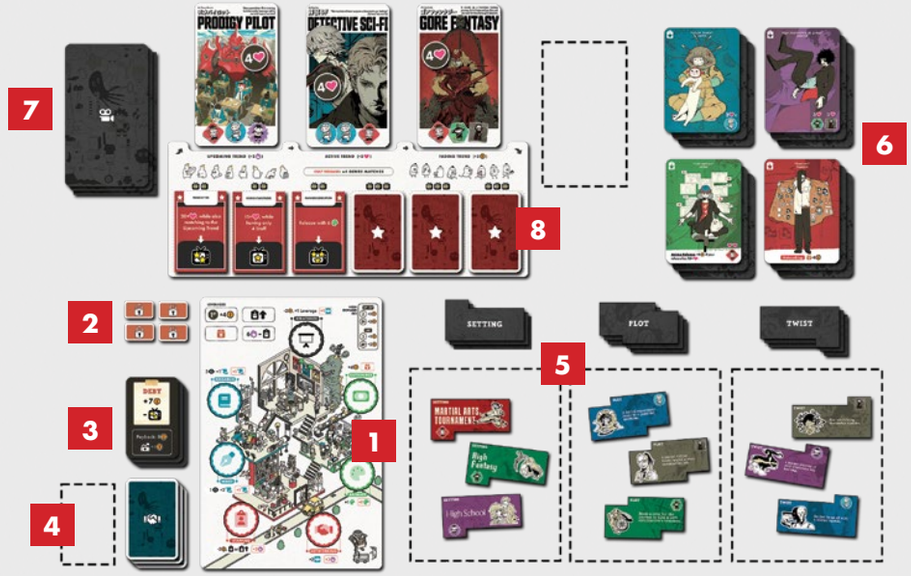
The **Action board** is a shared space where players will constantly interact. It uses a classic worker-placement mechanic, requiring players to think strategically and diversify their actions to avoid being blocked.

All **common pools** are also found here. These pools contain the cards and tokens available to all players during their turns.



CENTRAL AREA SETUP

The arrangement shown here is just one of many possible setups for the game. You can adjust the layout based on the number of players and the size of your table, arranging the parts as you see fit.



1. Place the **Action board** on the table.

2. Place all 4 **Lock tokens** near the left side of the Action board.

3. Place all the **Debt cards** in a stack next to the Action board.

4. Shuffle all **Network cards** (blue back + icon) and place them next to the Action board. Leave a space to the side of the deck for the discard pile.

5. Shuffle the **Script Parts** into 3 face-down stacks of matching types & shapes. Then reveal 3 from each stack into the area below each stack. Leave enough space for more to be revealed later.

6. Separate all **Genki Staff cards** (those with the icon on their back) into decks according to their colors. Shuffle each deck separately and place them face-down onto the table. Flip the top card of each deck face-up.

7. Shuffle all **Trend cards** and place the deck on the table. Put the **Trend board** beside it. Deal 3 cards from it, placing them into the open slots on the top edge of the Trend board. Place a **Bonus token** on top of each revealed card. Leave a space to the right of the board for the discard.

8. Shuffle the **Opportunity cards** (red back + icon). Deal 6 cards in the open slots on the lower part of the **Trend board**. Flip the 3 leftmost cards face-up, and keep the 3 rightmost cards face-down. Return the leftover cards to the box.

The second key area represents each player's Studio, where individual management actions are tracked. Players also manage their staff, budget, and the anime in production here.

On the right side of each Studio board, you'll find a track showing each player's Reputation Score, which starts at 0. The main goal of the game is simple: **earn the most Reputation points** and prove yourself worthy of the investors' support.

WHAT ARE YOU TRYING TO ACHIEVE?



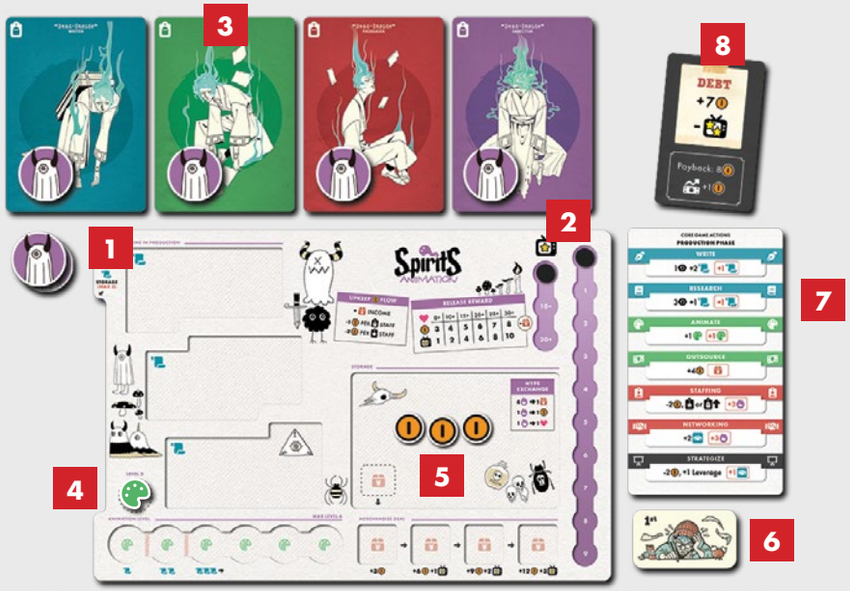
A player's primary goal during each round is to release anime. This is the main way they will earn money and score points throughout the game.

The game is played over 4 rounds. Each player has the option to release one anime per round, representing a year of production.

Players have everything they need to create anime at the very start of the game. They can either focus on improving the conditions of their studio, aiming at big releases that will score big, or start releasing humble productions as soon as possible, rushing to take advantage of limited market opportunities.



PLAYER STUDIO SETUP



1. Give each player a **Studio board** and 6 matching **Studio Action tokens** (colored plastic chips).

2. Give each player 2 **Point trackers** and and set each track to 0. Whenever players gain points, move these accordingly.

3. Give each player 4 **Dead-Inside Staff cards** (those with the icon on their top left side), one of each color. Place 1 **Studio Action token** on top of each Staff card, leaving 2 Action tokens in reserve.

4. Give each player 1 token. Place it in the location marked.

5. Give the **1st player token** to the player who most recently finished a season of an anime (or randomly choose one player).

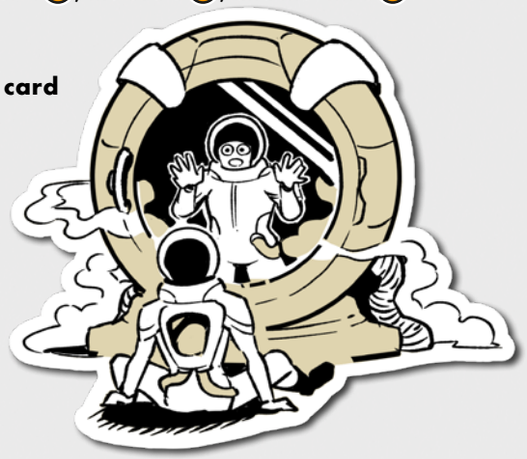
6. Give the 1st player 3, the 2nd player 4, the 3rd 5, and the 4th 6.

7. Give each player a **Player Aid** card.

8. Optional: Give each player a **Debt card** (but not the 7 described on the card).

Create a pool of tokens in an easy to access location for all players.





ACTION SYSTEM INTRODUCTION

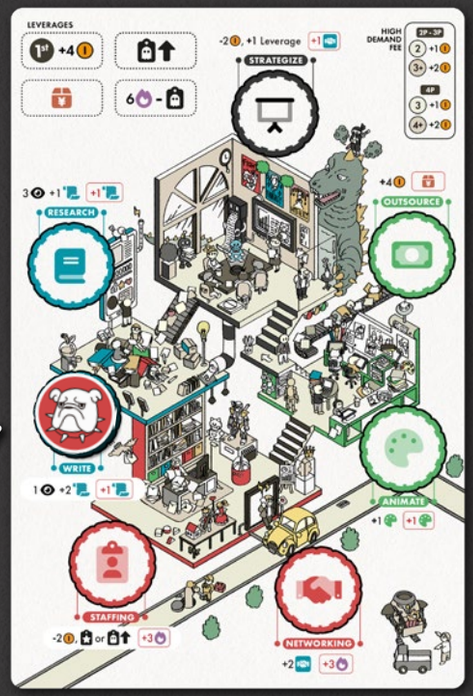
The actions players perform each round are taken by their Staff. Players begin with 4 Staff cards, can promote them and acquire more as the game progresses.

Staff cards can either be **available** or **spent**. To differentiate between these two states, players use **Studio Action tokens** placed on the cards. When a player uses a Staff member to perform an action, they move the Studio Action token from the staff card taking the action to one of the action slots on the Action board. **A Staff card with no action token on it is considered spent.**

There are some restrictions on the actions each Staff member may take, as well as additional costs when action spaces become crowded—but we'll dive into those details in a future chapter!







GAME PHASES OVERVIEW

JISOGI is played over 4 rounds. At the end of the the 4th round, the game ends, and the player with the most Reputation points ( ) wins. Each round consists of the following three phases:

1. **PRODUCTION PHASE**
2. **RELEASE PHASE**
3. **UPKEEP PHASE**

The main phase of the game is the **Production Phase**. Here staff actions are used to hire or promote staff, research, write and animate your next anime release, and more.

Starting with the first player and proceeding clockwise, each player takes turns moving one of their available staff card's studio action tokens to an action space on the board to perform that action. This continues until all players have no more available Staff.

After the Production Phase, players move to the **Release Phase**. In this phase, players may release one anime each and gain the rewards for it. If they do, they also activate Merchanise Deals (, a source of income) and may score Opportunity cards (, objectives all players race to complete first).

Finally, the round concludes with the **Upkeep Phase**, where debts may be repaid or left to accumulate, staff salaries are paid, and several reset triggers occur including replenishing staff cards with studio action tokens.

Money ( ) is the most basic resource of the game. But money is tight for anime studios. You need it to pay for a few critical actions, to follow players taking high demand actions, and most importantly to pay your staff's increasing wages.



If you ever need to pay more money than you have, you automatically take a debt card to gain 7 more money. These loans help you get out of trouble, but your debts accumulate, and if unpaid, they will damage your reputation score. Manage your money and debts wisely to win!



SCRIPT PARTS



*After an anime is released, move all 3 In Production to the right side of the player board. Some cards in the game will refer to your released animes.

One core element of every anime are its 3 **Script Parts** (represented by the icon). These uniquely shaped pieces represent the parts of a story and their genres. Each anime must have one of each type of in order to be released: **Setting**, **Plot**, and **Twist**.

A 's color and icon represents its genre. There are 5 different genres: **Action**, **Fantasy**, **Slice of Life**, **Sci-Fi**, and **Horror**.

are picked from the shared central pool of divided by their 3 types. When revealing new (p.13), players can reveal from any pile (either from the same pile or a mix of them). If one of the 3 revealed pools is ever empty, refill it with 1 new after the action being taken is complete.

Whenever players acquire a , they **place it to the left of their player boards**. The in this area are considered to be **In Storage** (players can have a maximum of 5 In Storage, discarding excess back to the common pool at the end of each player's turn).

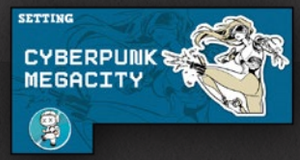
Players can move to the **In Production** slots of their player board, at any time as free action, but once placed, they cannot be swapped out and must be used for their next release.



RED
ACTION



GREEN
FANTASY



BLUE
SCI-FI



BROWN
HORROR



PURPLE
SLICE OF LIFE

ART

The other integral part of any anime is its art. In JISOGI this is represented by the **Animation Level Token** ( ). The higher the , the prettier their anime will be!

Whenever levels are gained, the Animation Level Token is moved from the level 0 space into the 1st slot of its track, placed at the bottom left of the Studio board. Whenever any new level is gained, move the token one slot to the right.

Players must have at least 1 In Production to start gaining levels. In order to acquire their 2nd level, they must have 2 In Production. After they have all 3 In Production, they can acquire **up to** 6 levels (excess levels are ignored).

If an anime has exactly 3 and at least 1 level, that anime **can be released.** These 2 aspects will be multiplied together to determine your anime release's base popularity during the release phase (p.19).

Once released, the token goes back to the level 0 slot, and the tokens are moved out from the player board and kept to the right side of it (these will be important later to fulfill the conditions of some cards).



Example: 2 levels have been acquired for this release, going from level 0 to 2. This is a valid action since 2 are in place. If this player wants to acquire more levels they must first fix a 3rd .



Example: a player adds 2 levels to an anime that already has 2 levels and 3 . With 4 levels in total this anime will be more popular.

In the Animation Level space of the Studio board, there are icons in place to remind players of the requirements to place levels.



PRODUCTION PHASE / ACTION SYSTEM

Now that we know what it takes to make a great anime, let's learn the actions that will help players get there. JISOGI's action system uses 2 components: the **Staff cards**, and the **Studio Action tokens**.

Each of your Staff cards begins the round with an action token on it. During the Production Phase of the game, players take turns taking 1 action each, clockwise, moving an action token from a staff card to a valid action space on the board. These each allow you to take specific actions and gain certain resources.

Players can choose to place Action tokens for actions they have already chosen. There are no limits to how many tokens can be in the same stack, but the higher the stack, the more expensive that action will become when taken again (covered on p.16).



A player can choose to finish their round without placing all their Action tokens. Once they decide this, they remove all unused Action tokens on their Staff, indicating they are finished for this phase.

There are some limitations to the placement of your Studio Action tokens, which is where your **Staff cards** type's come into play.

There are 4 types of Staff cards: **Writers**, ***Artists***, ***Producers***, and ***Directors***. Each of these types is restricted to performing particular actions. Once a token is removed from a Staff card, the placement restrictions of that card type must be respected (after all, if you ask a Producer to draw your animations you will most certainly fail in that task).

Players **start the game with 4 Staff cards**, one of each type. Your initial staff are traumatized by their past work conditions and are considered **Dead-Inside**. They do the minimum work possible, and are incapable of earning action bonuses. As players develop their Studios, they will be able to hire new **Genki Staff** and even inspire enthusiasm in their Dead-Inside Staff by offering them a promotion.

The maximum amount of Staff cards a player can have is 6.

CORE GAME ACTIONS

There are 7 potential actions a Staff member can perform.

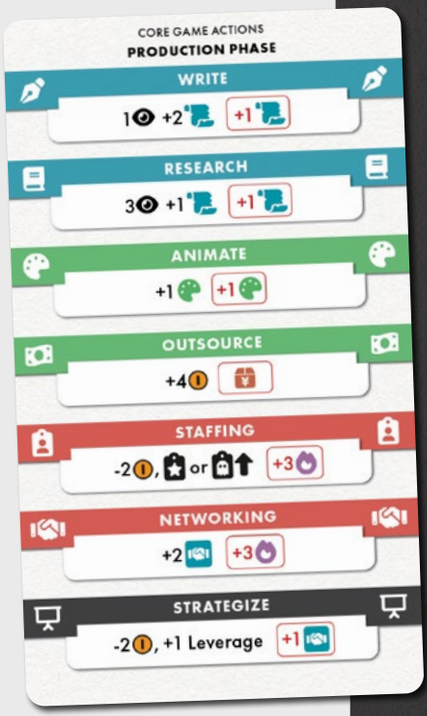
Writers can perform the **blue actions**, **Artists** the **green actions**, and **Producers** the **red actions**. The **Strategize action** can be performed by all types of Staff.

Directors can perform any type of action.

The **Write** and **Research** actions allow players to gain . The symbol refers to revealing a number of from any of the 3 face down piles and adding them to their associated common pools. The symbol when shown together with a +number refers to picking a number of pieces from any common pool and placing them in your storage.

The **Animate** action allows players to gain levels and the **Outsource** action to get .

The ***Staffing*** action allows players to either gain new Staff or Promote existing Staff. 2 must always be paid to perform this action.

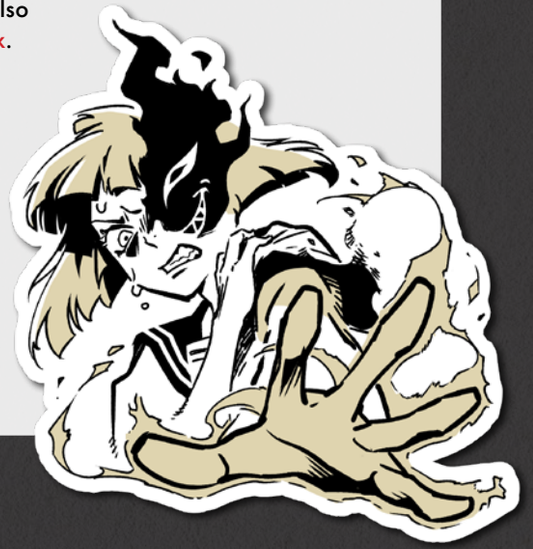


The **Networking** action allows players to draw Network cards (p.20).

The **Strategize** action has its own special rules (p.17). 2 must always be paid to perform this action.

Dead-Inside Staff cards perform only the basic part of each action, without counting the bonus listed inside that action's red box. However, **Genki Staff** cards perform the basic action, and also the bonus shown of that action's red box.

Players can increase the rewards of these actions by using Staff abilities (p.14) and/or Network cards (p.15). These effects often have different trigger conditions, and multiple effects may be triggered simultaneously. In such cases, the player chooses the order in which to resolve them, activating each effect one by one.



GENKI STAFF

Genki Staff cards can be acquired to improve or increase the number of actions a player may perform each round. These cards are recognized by their more lively illustration, and also by the icon on their top left.

Genki Staff are still restricted by their type (Artist, Producer, Writer) but they also collect the bonus listed inside the red box shown next to the description of each action.

Some Genki Staff also have an **activation skill** described in the bottom white part of their card. Each skill is activated on 1 of 4 occasions:

- When the listed **action** is performed by this Staff—and this Staff only (e.g. Write, or Animate);
- Whenever an Anime is released during the **Release Phase**. Players can collect the rewards before the popularity score is calculated (p.19);
- At any moment during the **Production Phase**;
- At any moment during the **Upkeep Phase**.



Some Genki Staff also often have **preferred genres** that they enjoy working on the most. These are denoted by the genre icons shown at the bottom right of many Genki cards. If no icons are shown here, the Staff does not have a preferred genre.

Players gain or bonuses when releasing an anime that contains genres matching their Genki Staff's preferences (p.19).

Note: Genki (元気) has many meanings, but it is mostly used to express a person who is "motivated", "energetic", or simply "feeling good".

STAFFING (HIRE/PROMOTE)

There are 2 ways to gain Genki Staff: **Hiring** or **Promoting**.

When **Hiring ( )**, players may pick any of the face-up Genki Staff cards in the common pool. They place it next to the other Staff **but do not place a Studio Action token** on them. The new Staff is onboarding and won't be able to take an action until the following round. However, Upkeep, Release skills and genre bonuses do trigger while staff are onboarding.

The other way to acquire Genki Staff is by **Promoting ( )**. In this case, players replace a Dead-Inside Staff card they own with a Genki Staff from the common pool (place the new card on top of it). A Dead-Inside Staff **can only** be Promoted to a Genki Staff of the same type. If the promoted Staff still has a Studio Action token on it, **it can perform an action in the same round** it is promoted.

The Staff decks in the common pool are immediately refilled (flip the top card face-up) when a Staff card is taken from it. Also, during the Upkeep phase, the common pool is refreshed: all face-up Staff cards in the common pool are placed at the bottom of their respective decks and a new batch is turned face-up from the top.

If a player reaches the limit of 6 Staff cards, they may still promote a Genki staff to a different Genki staff of the same type, if they wish. That action is done by performing a and follows the same limitations.

NETWORK CARDS



Network cards are powerful one-time-use cards gained through the use of the **Networking action**. Each lists one or more **trigger actions** (on the top of the card) that players must take in order to play the card and gain its benefit.

After players finish the base action used to trigger the card, they can then reveal it, collect its benefits, and discard the .

Collected during a turn are kept face-down in front of the player who collected them until their turn is finished.

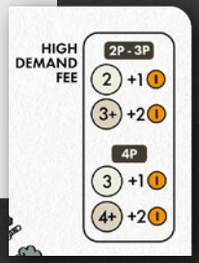
Only 1 card can be played with each action, and its effects can only be triggered once.

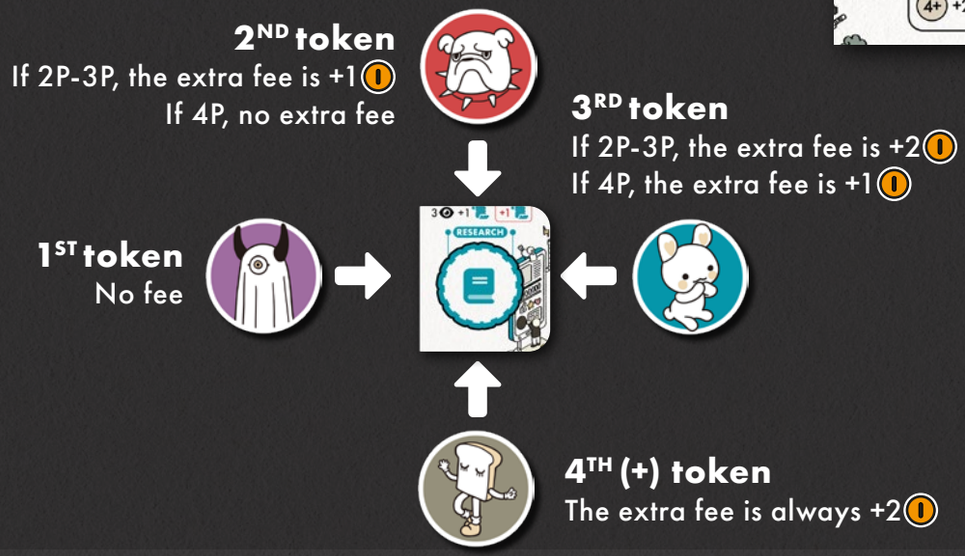
If the deck runs out of cards, shuffle the discard pile and make it the new deck.

HIGH DEMAND FEE

Staff cards represent the core full-time employees of the studios, but their actions are really made possible by the hard work of the freelancers they direct. When the market gets too saturated, the price of hiring freelancers also inevitably increases.

The **High Demand Fee** triggers when a player places their Studio Action token **on an action spot that already contains one or more action tokens**. In a **2-3 player** game, placing the first Studio action token is free, placing the second costs +1, and placing any further Studio Action token costs +2. If playing with **4 players**, only the 3rd token costs +1 and the 4th token onwards costs +2.



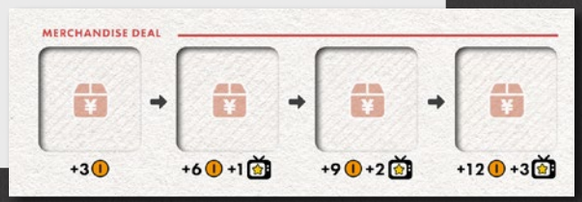


MERCHANDISE DEAL

Merchandising offers a vital way to gain income during the game. Whenever gaining ¥, players either acquire a ¥ token and place it in their inventory area, or, if they already have a ¥ token there, activate it, placing it in the leftmost empty space on their Merchandising Deal Track.

During each Upkeep phase players gain the rewards listed below their rightmost ¥ token (and not the rewards before it).

Whenever a player gains ¥, while they already have 4 activated ¥, they instead gain 1 per ¥ gained.



STRATEGIZE ACTION

On the top of the Action board, there is an action space called **Strategize**. Whenever a player uses it, they pay 2 to select one of the four available **Leverages** boxes and gain what is inside it.

Whenever a player perfoms this action, place a **Lock token** on top of the chosen Leverage. For the remainder of the round, **no other player can pick that same Leverage**.

Here is a breakdown of each Leverage:

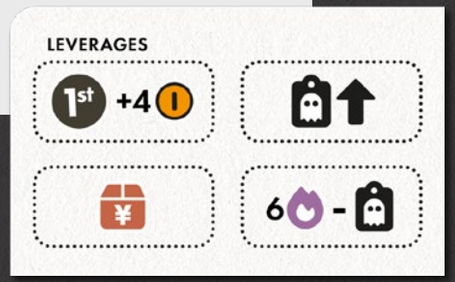
01: Gain the 1st player token and +4. Starting from this round release phase, **you are the first player**. The 1st player token does not pass automatically between players at the end of the round. It is only passed when a player uses this action.



02: Promote a Dead-Inside Staff to a Genki Staff.

03: Gain a ¥ new token or activate a ¥ in your inventory.

04: Gain 6 Hype minus the number of Dead Inside Staff you currently own.





During each upkeep phase, remove the lock tokens from Leverages.

HYPE

Several actions and cards award players with **Hype** (). Hype is a multi-use resource that players can exchanged **at any time, as a free action**. can be exchange for money (), to gain merchandise (¥), or for popularity (). The exchange rate for each is shown on the Studio board.

If there are no more in the supply, replace individual in storage for the 3 tokens, representing 3x. In the rare case there are still no tokens left in the supply, players gain in exchange for the .



RELEASE PHASE / TREND CARDS

During the **Release Phase** each player will have the chance to release 1 anime each, in turn order. Releasing an anime gains you money, points, a Merchandise Deal, and a chance to score an opportunity card.

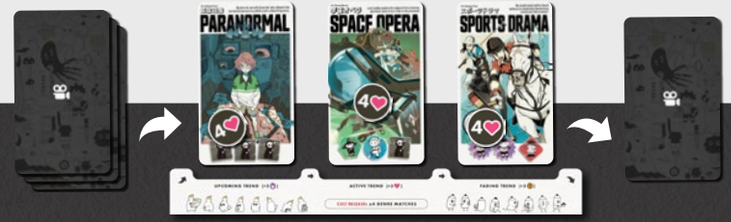
Whenever releasing an anime, players will check the genre icons on their 3 In Production, and **may choose 1 of the 3 face up Trend Cards** to follow (to compare their release with). Each genre on their anime's can match with 1 icon on the Trend card, in any desired order.

Players can only choose a Trend card to follow if they have at least 1 genre match with it—if they have 0 matches with all 3 Trend cards, they release it as a **Cult Release** (p.19).

In the example to the right, there are 2 genre matches between the player's and the Trend card - **Action** and **Horror** (the order of the icons does not matter). Having more matches raises the Popularity Score of this release (p.19).

The 3 Trend cards displayed on the trend board each also **provide a bonus when followed**. The leftmost Upcoming Trend earns you 2; the center Active trend earns you 3 this release; and the rightmost Fading trend earns you 3.

At the end of the Release Phase (even if no one released this round), **move all the Trend cards one space to the right**, discarding the Fading Trend and revealing a new Upcoming Trend. When a new Trend card is revealed, place a 4 token on top of it.





POPULARITY SCORE

Every time a player releases an anime, no matter how small, they will be rewarded with money and points.

However, if their anime is impressive visually and aligns with the trends, they can gain a bigger reward. To determine the reward level, players must first calculate the released anime's **Popularity Score** (p.19).

After calculating an anime's total, consult the Release Reward table on your player board to determine how much and you earned.

HOW TO CALCULATE THE POPULARITY SCORE

First, determine the number of **genre icon matches** the anime has with the Trend Card being followed. Then multiply that number by the level.

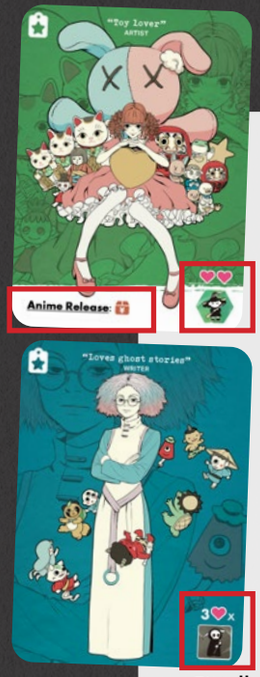
Let's say a player's has 2 genre matches, and they have reached level 4 for their release. **2 genre matches x4 = 8** Popularity Score.

If a player has 0 matches with all 3 Trends cards, they release it as a **Cult Release** and multiply their by 4 (as if they had 4 genre matches).

After finding the base score, players proceed to add the bonuses listed below.



POPULARITY BONUSES



The first way to improve an anime's is the **Genki Staff bonuses**. Whenever releasing an anime, check if any of the Genki Staff **preferred genres** (icons on the bottom right of the card) match any of your anime release's In Production. If so, check the bonus above the genre icons and immediately gain those.

Some Staff cards have the "x" symbol in their genre bonus. When scoring those gain the listed bonus **for each** in the player's anime that match the Staff preferred genre (bonus levels are gained immediately, and the base must be calculated again).

Some Genki Staff also have an "**Anime Release**" **activation skills**. Whenever the owner of the card releases an anime during the Release Phase, gain the bonuses listed.

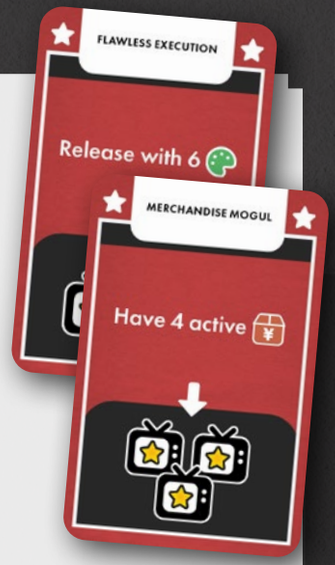
The third way to gain more bonus is to spend **Hype** (). For each spent, players add +1 to their anime's total.

Finally, if a player is the **first to match all 3 genres to the trend card they are following,** they add that Trend's 4 bonus to their release's total. Remove the 4 token from the Trend card and keep it in the supply until a new trend is revealed.

Cult releases do not gain the 4 and do not trigger any other bonus that refer to a specific Trend card position.



OPPORTUNITY CARDS



Opportunity cards (★) represent shared objectives that all players can try to fulfill after releasing an anime. After a player releases an anime and calculate their rewards, they may fulfill 1★ of the face-up available Opportunity cards they meet the conditions for.

Each face-up ★ card has a condition displayed at the top, detailing the requirement to score it, and a reward at the bottom, indicating the Reputation points (📺★) gained by scoring it.

Whenever you fulfill an Opportunity card, gain the 📺★ indicated on the card, plus any bonus 📺★ listed on the Trend board above the card.

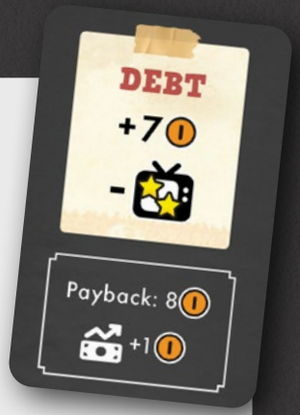
Return fulfilled ★ cards by any player to the box, without replacing it with new ones.

At the end of the first round, flip the 4th ★ card in the Trend board face-up. At the end of the 2nd round, flip the 5th card face-up, and at the end of the 3rd round, flip the last face-down ★ card face-up.

If more than one player can fulfill the conditions of a ★ card during the same Release phase, only the player who releases first gets to score it. Player order is crucial to this step.



DEBT CARDS



Any time a player needs to pay 🪙 for something (whether an action or salaries), but doesn't have enough 🪙 for it, they must immediately take a **Debt card** in order to cover the cost.

A Debt card provides players with 7🪙, and many reduces their final score by -2📺★ if not paid off. Players may pay back Debt cards during the Upkeep phase by paying 8🪙 to the supply. Paying debts is not mandatory, even if players have enough 🪙 to do so.

Also during the Upkeep phase, Interest hits (📈) and the cost to pay back Debts increases. Place a 🪙 on top of each Debt card in a player's possession, effectively increasing each payback cost by 1🪙. This happens every round.

Players may not take Debt cards to pay off other Debt cards.

UPKEEP PHASE

During the **Upkeep Phase** complete the following steps in order. To help you stay on track, the player aid also includes this list - be sure to reference it during the game!

1. Gain the rewards listed below your rightmost Active 💴 (p.16).

2. Pay off **Debt cards** (optional).

3. Raise the interest 📈 on each of your **Debt cards**.

4. Pay **Salaries** (see below).

5. Recover all **Studio Action Tokens** (p.12), placing them on top of all Staff cards.

6. Refill the **Genki Staff** common pool, moving the top card of each deck to its bottom, and flipping face-up the top card of the deck (p.14).

7. Reset Strategize leverage's (p.17).

8. Flip the leftmost face down Opportunity card face up.

Note: Steps 5-8 can be ignored in the last round of the game.

SALARY

As expected, Staff do not work for free. The more productive and confident they are, the higher their salary requirements. Dead-Inside Staff each cost 1🪙, and Genki Staff cost 2🪙 when paying Salaries.

Salaries are only paid during the Upkeep Phase but they are one of the most important considerations to be made before deciding on expanding your team.



Total salary in this example: 7🪙

END OF THE GAME

The game ends at the end of the 4th round's Upkeep Phase, and **whoever has the most points wins**!

For each unpaid Debt card, its owner loses -2.

If, after all negative debt points are accounted for, there is a tie, **the player with most wins the game**. If there is still a tie, players share the victory.

SCORE CAP

There is a Reputation cap of 29 points. For every scored after that, players instead gain 1 . This cap represents the limits of reputation, since it is profit that will determine your studio's longevity in the end.

JISOGI was created to emulate the hard truth of running a company with a limited budget and low-profit margins. **Getting debt cards is a normal and almost unavoidable part of the early game**. Players must find a balance between income and expenditures, making sure to collect the payback for their investments before the end.

If your group **isn't comfortable with the concept of debt** or might feel overwhelmed by the pressure of rising interest rates, we recommend skipping the interest increase and keeping the payback cost fixed at 8 throughout the game.

On the other hand, If your group enjoys the challenge and want to try something even harder, the user @JustAModestMan offered a game variant called "Despair" on JISOGI's BGG forum.

In this variant, instead of the interest increase, players have to pay 1 per debt card they own every round, at the same moment they pay for the salaries of their team.

This can lead to a very realistic debt spiral that might be impossible to come out from. If you, like us, get excited with the challenge, try it out!





Let's review all we have learned so far, by checking this mid-game player board.

1. **Spent Staff**. Its Studio Action token has been moved to the Action board.
2. **Available Staff**. Since it has a Studio Action token on it, can still be used this round.
3. **Unused Studio Action token**. The player still has space to hire one more Staff.
4. **In Production**. Cannot be removed anymore.
5. **In Storage**. A player can have a max of 5 in this space.
6. Previously **released anime**.
7. **Animation** level - current at 2.
8. **1 Active** . Another is inactive, therefore kept in the Storage area.
9. Currently owned **Network cards** (kept hidden from other players).
10. **Debt cards** owned. The on top of it is a reminder that interest on the card has increased the cost to 9 .

A ROUND EXAMPLE

For this example, we are following Haruka as she takes her turns in between other players' turns. She has one left over Sci-fi story part, 3 hype tokens, has hired 1 extra worker and promoted her Producer and her Artists in previous rounds.



- PRODUCTION PHASE -

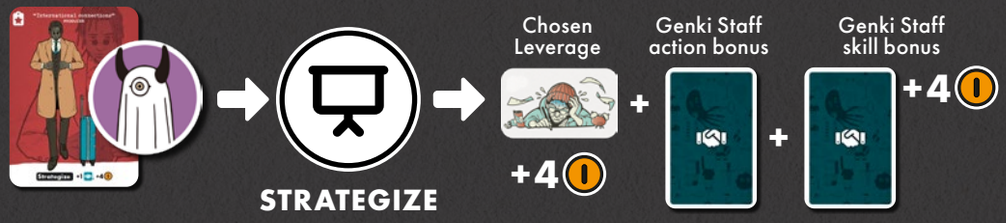
Her 1st action is to **Research**. To make sure she gets exactly what she needs, she uses a Genki Staff with a skill that gives her +2 Reveal (). She reveals a total of 5 and then picks () 1 (Basic action reward) +1 (Genki Staff red box bonus).



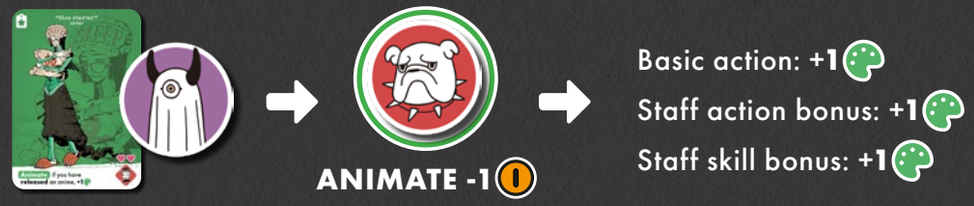
Her 2nd action is to go **Networking**. She wants to power up her future actions, so she draws 2 Network cards, which become available to use from her next action.



Her 3rd action is to **Strategize**. First she pays 2 (Strategize action cost). For her Leverage, she decides to take the 1st player token and gain +4. She gains +1 as a bonus for using a Genki Staff to perform that action. Lastly, Because of her Genki Staff's Skill, she also gains +1 and +4.



For her 4th action, Haruka decides to **Animate**. Another player has already performed that action during this round, so she has to pay the High Demand Fee 1. She gains +3: 1 extra from the Genki Staff action bonus, and another from the card skill activation.



For her last action, Haruka decides to **Write**. She wants to start gathering for her next round, but, more importantly, she wants to use the Network card she got on her 2nd action, to gain some .



- RELEASE PHASE -



With 3/3 she decides that her anime is now ready to be released. She follows the Fading Trend because her anime's 3 match all 3 of its genres, and one of her Genki staff adds another 2 bonus -Fantasy is their preferred Genre.

She also matches the 3 genres of this Trend card and claims the 4 bonus (still available, since no other player has met the requirements yet). Finally, she decides to spend all 5 of her to gain another 5.

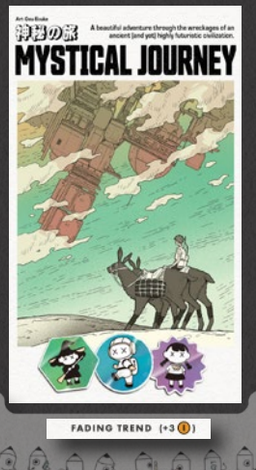
GENRE MATCHES		STAFF BONUS	USES	
3 x 3	4	+2	5 +5	=20

She checks her playerboard and sees that a release with 20+ grants her the following reward:

6 + 6



By releasing an anime (of any), she also gains +.
By following the Fading Trend, she also gains a bonus +3.



PITCH ROOM
NARRATIVE GAME MODE



GAME OVERVIEW

Instead of exploring all the aspects of running an Anime Studio, this game mode focuses on a single creative meeting, where the team debates what the studio's next big release should be.

Each player will pitch one script to the group, complete with Setting, Plot, and Twist. At the end, everyone votes to decide which story was the most captivating. The uniqueness of this mode comes from how players interact during the process, often leading to absurd elements that must be included into the stories.

This mode feels more like an improvisation workshop than the management game offered in the base rules. It turns the flavor elements of the main game—normally separate from the mechanics—into the game's core pieces.

NORMAL GAME MODE: 3-6 Players
*With 2 players, skip the voting step and just enjoy a more relaxed collaborative experience.

SETUP



TREND CARDS

Shuffle the Trend cards and deal 3 to each player. Everyone chooses 1 and places it face-up in front of them. This will be refered to as their **Core Theme**.



SCRIPT PARTS

Shuffle the Script Parts into 3 separate face-down piles (Setting, Plot, Twist). Place these piles in the center of the table.



"WHAT IF" TOKEN

Give each player 1 Studio Action Token. In this mode they will be called "**WHAT IF" Tokens** (their colors do not matter).

Jisogi: Pitch Room is played over 3 rounds: the **Setting**, the **Plot**, and the **Twist** round. Each round is split into two phases: **Brainstorm** and **Pitch**.

BRAINSTORM PHASE

- Randomly choose a starting player; play proceeds clockwise.
- Deal 3 Script Parts of the current type to each player (Setting, Plor, or Twist). On your turn, select 1 Script Part and play it in front of another player without a Script Part.
- Continue until all players have a Script Part in front of them. Discard any remaining unplayed Script Parts to the supply.





Example
Core Theme: Witch School

Script Part: Countryside Village

PITCH PHASE

Each player now tells a story that combines their Core Theme with the Script Part in front of them. Turn order doesn't matter in this phase—any player who feels ready may begin, and the rest can follow in whatever order they like.

"For many decades this countryside village has thrived as the best tea producers in the country. What no one knows is that the brewers are witches, who also run a side business selling potions."

After a player shares their story, the others may each ask one (only one) question. These can point out inconsistencies, demand clarifications, or request references.

- "Are they evil witches, or more like quirky old ladies?"
- "Which country is this set in?"
- "I get the witch part, but what about the "school" in your Core Theme?"

Players don't have to ask questions, but unanswered or unsatisfying answers may cause the group to lose confidence in the pitch. While sabotage isn't the goal, everyone should act as if they are studio executives evaluating a proposal.

After all players finish telling their stories, the Setting Round ends, and the **Plot round** starts. It plays just like the Setting Round, but now the story must follow both the Core Theme and the established Setting. During the Plot round only, when placing Script Parts, player order starts from the last player in the Setting Round, moving counter-clockwise instead.

Example
Plot: Transported to a magical world, must adapt to a new life.

"A spy from a rival company moves into the tea village, hoping to uncover its secret. Each episode follows a series of comical incidents, where the witches secretly interfere with his life, driving him to the brink of madness."



Again, each player faces questions after their pitch. Some examples:

- "Do they hate the guy or are they just friendly messing up with him?"
- "Is the guy good with tea or just some corporate lackey?"

The final round follows the same structure as the 1st round. Players now incorporate the Twist Script Part into their evolving story. After all three rounds (Setting, Plot, Twist), players vote for their favorite story. The player with the **most votes wins**!

"WHAT IF" TOKENS

In real creative meetings, unsolicited opinions are inevitable. The classic phrase—"That's nice, but what if...?"—often throws a wrench into the process, making things messier than they need to be.

In **Jisogi: Pitch Room**, this dynamic becomes part of the game. To keep things fun (and not as long as real studio meetings), each player may only use their What If Token **once per game**, and only for a single, simple suggestion.

How it works



- After a player finishes telling their story (during any round), another player may spend their What If Token to jump in with a suggestion.
- The storyteller must accept and immediately weave the suggestion into their story.
- Only one suggestion can be made per story. If multiple players want to jump in, the one sitting closest (clockwise) to the first player of that round gets priority.
- Each player can only be targeted by a What If Token once per game. Keep the token in front of the targeted player as a reminder.
- Using your token is optional. If you never find the right moment, that's fine—you'll simply miss the chance to make someone else's story harder (which some players might even consider a kindness!).

GUIDELINES

Players should not try to sabotage each other. Suggestions must make at least minimal sense within the established concept and should add layers or subtle complications rather than completely derailing the story. Suggestions should also be tied directly to the story element currently being pitched (e.g., don't suggest a new Setting when the player is presenting a Twist).

Good examples

"But what if this story was set in the 1980s?"
"But what if the plot had a hint of romance?"
"But what if the main character was unusually attractive?"
"But what if they had no money left in their bank account?"
"But what if one of them wasn't telling the truth?"

Bad examples

"But what if this children's show suddenly became a dark zombie apocalypse survival story?"
"But what if instead of a crime thriller we make a love story between the detective and his secretary?"
"But what if the villains were secretly their future selves trying to change history?"



Good suggestions should continue the story beats without twisting the narrative into something unrecognizable.

SCRIPT PART TYPES

One of the biggest challenges in this game (and also in the real life situations we are simulating) is discussing the wrong parts of a story at the wrong time. It's natural for things like character motivation and setting to overlap, but if the discussion isn't kept focused, these meetings can go nowhere.

In this game, the structure is guided by the Script Parts themselves, giving players a clear prompt to follow. To make this even easier, let's clarify what each Script type refers to.



SETTINGS define the world where the story takes place. They can be broad—like a historical era or a country—or very specific, such as a workplace or a single street. The focus should not be on the main character or their motivation, but on the environment and unique details that make the location interesting.

PLOTS establish the core characters, and also the events or challenges that drive the story forward. They not only set who is the main character, but give them something to do, overcome, or discover.

TWISTS add an unexpected turn that changes the meaning or direction of the story. They don't erase the Setting or Plot but build on them, adding surprise, tension, or a new perspective.

TREND CARDS / CORE THEME

Each Trend Card shows three genres. In the base game, these genres play a central role, but in Jisogi: Pitch Room, they serve mainly as a reference tool. They guide players toward Script Parts that naturally fit with their chosen Core Theme.

During each round, players will have 3 Script Parts in hand. With so many possible directions to take, it can feel overwhelming to decide which story pieces fit together. This is where the genre icons on the Trend Cards become useful: if you're unsure, try matching colors or genres, as this often leads to strong connections.

Of course, a competitive player might deliberately give someone Script Parts from completely unrelated genres, hoping to trip them up. But in truth, these odd pairings often produce the most unique and memorable stories. Above all, remember the golden rule of improvisation: be kind to each other and focus on keeping everyone entertained!



"In a future where robots are commonly employed for entertainment, a theater in Japan becomes famous for staging period plays with giant robots as the performers. An engineer, who has devoted his entire life to one of these robots grows increasingly jealous of the bond forming between the robot's AI and its human pilot.
The drama escalates when they discover that the AI has been manipulating not only them, but the entire team, whispering promises of love while secretly pursuing glory and fame."



SOLO MODE

The solo mode of Jisogi offers two main benefits: helping you learn the game before playing with others and providing unique challenges.

To play solo, you'll follow most of the same steps as the multiplayer setup, with a few key adjustments: Remove all **Network cards** with the icon in their lower-right corner. Shuffle these cards separately and place them in a dedicated deck. Collect 6 Studio Action tokens from a Studio different from the one you've chosen. Place these tokens next to this new deck.

Take the **Solo Challenge cards** and place them on the table. Choose 1 of the 8 available modes. For first-time players, we highly recommend starting with the "Learning the Game" mode. Check the special rules on the Solo Challenge card for any other setup changes.

These are the key pieces of information on the Solo Challenge cards:

Objective: Refers to the goal players must achieve to win the game.

Rounds: Refers to the amount of rounds players will have in order to achieve the objective. Rounds can be tracked by the movement of the Opportunity cards ( ).

High-demand tokens: Refers to a solo-only rule. At the start of every Production Phase, shuffle the newly created Network card deck (the cards with the symbol) and draw cards equal to the number listed in the challenge. Check the actions on the top of each revealed card, choose one, and place another Studio's Action token on that space in the Action board—as if another player had taken it. Place 2 tokens instead if "double" is written after the number. Ignore everything else on the cards. Do this for all cards revealed. You may not choose the same action with 2 different high demand cards.

Once this is done, return all drawn cards to the deck. Treat the Studio Action tokens as you would on the multiplayer game, removing all from the Action board at the Upkeep.

All solo modes follow one special rule regarding the **Trend cards**: At the end of the Release Phase, when prompted to discard the Fading Trend, also discard all cards that do not have a 4 on them. Fill all empty slots with new Trend cards.

For the solo mode only, do not automatically refill your Staff common pools after hiring/promoting a Staff. Only refresh all decks at the Upkeep phase as you normally would. Also, if a Staff card with the symbol on its top left is revealed, move it to the bottom of deck and reveal a new one.

Lastly, if not stated otherwise, always start with 1 Debt card.

The first two solo challenges are beginner-friendly and ideal for learning the game. However, challenges starting from #3 are considerably more difficult and are best attempted once comfortable with the game mechanics and familiar with the abilities of the various Staff cards.

Good luck!



CREDITS

Game & Art Direction: Rodrigo Esper

Producer: Naho Sakamoto

Lead Artists: Eisuke Gou and Senkawa Teien

Guest Artists: Thomas Romain, Yuu (Arcadia), Pancho Rabbit, Ivan Inagaki, Kenji Loo, Sushizawa

Cultural Advisor: Yumiko Yoshizawa, Thomas Romain

Graphic Design: Rodrigo Esper, Solitude, Good Games Publishing

Community Manager: Anne Ferrero

Game Development: Samba Estudios

Proof Reading: John Hodson, Rick Fuqua, Good Games Publishing

Kickstarter Trailer Video: Daren (darennn98)

Trailer Voice Actress: Minamo Aoto

Trailer 3d Model: AKA Virtual

Special thanks: Amy & Meg (Thinkerthemer), Mike DiLisio, Jay Bernardo, Bernardo Todesco, Johan Lagerqvist, Ray Hung, Will Feng, Sui Works, Lilly Wong, Harry Lee, Angela Lin, Mugen Gaming, and all our crowdfunding backers.

ESPER GAME STUDIO

www.esper.games